

TIMELINE

The civilizations of the region lasted for 2,000 years, until European explorers and their armies wiped them out.

500 BCE

The Zapotecs build Monte Alban as their capital and religious centre.

c.900–1000 CE
Toltecs build their capital at Tula, Mexico.



Toltec pottery

1325

Aztec city of Tenochtitlan founded on an island in Lake Texcoco.



Tenochtitlan marketplace

1519–21

Explorer and soldier Hernando Cortés conquers the Aztecs for Spain.

Cortés meeting Aztec leader Moctezuma II



1542

The Spanish establish a capital at Merida and the Maya resistance comes to an end.

1400 BCE

1400 BCE

The Olmecs build temples and carve colossal sculptures in northern Mexico.



Tikal temple

350 BCE

First great Maya city of Tikal built in the rainforest of Guatemala.

Incas begin to expand their empire through the central Andes.



Cuzco, Inca capital

c.1300

c.1438

Inca chief Pachacuti takes power. City of Machu Picchu is built.



Machu Picchu

1471

Tupac becomes king of the Incas and pushes far south to expand the empire.

1502

Moctezuma II begins his reign over ten million Aztecs. The empire is at its height.

1532

The Inca empire ends when Spanish warrior Francisco Pizarro captures and kills the Inca emperor, Atahualpa.

1700 CE

1697

The very last Maya outpost, Tayasal, falls to the Spanish.

GODS AND GODDESSES

The Mesoamericans and Incas worshipped many gods, most of them to do with nature or farming. People would ask the gods for good weather to make crops grow, or for better health for themselves and their families.



CHALCHIUHTLICUE
Aztec goddess of water and storms.



VIRACOCHA
Most important god of the Incas.



XOLOTL
Aztec god of death and lightning.



TZULTACAH
A group of Maya thunder-gods.



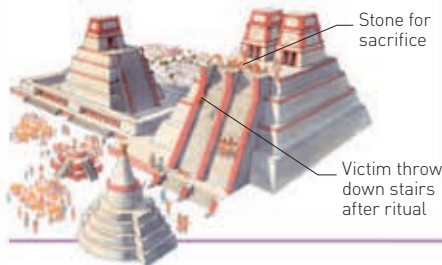
MAMA KILLA
Inca goddess of the moon.



MAIZE GOD
Unnamed, shaven-headed Maya god.

RITUAL AND SACRIFICE

Sacrifice was a vital religious ritual. Animals and humans were offered up to feed the gods so that they would look after the earth.



AZTEC WARRIORS

War was a way of life for the Aztecs. Apart from gaining new land, the main reason for going to war was to capture enemy warriors for sacrifice to the gods.

AT 17, YOUNG AZTEC MEN WERE SENT OFF TO CAPTURE THEIR FIRST PRISONER



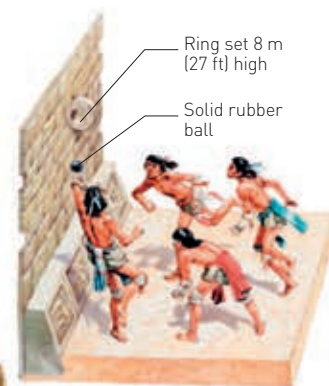
JAGUAR WARRIORS
For taking captives, Aztec warriors were awarded distinctive costumes.



AZTEC APPRENTICE WARRIOR
Carrying wooden spear tipped with sharp stone.

FUN AND GAMES

Ulama was a fast and furious ball game played by various cultures, including the Aztecs. We don't know the exact rules, but the aim was for two teams on a special court to try to put a ball through a ring set into a wall.



ART AND CRAFTS

The pottery, carvings, ceramics, and metalware left behind by the Mesoamerican and ancient Peruvian cultures are a valuable source of information about the way they lived, their ideas about life, and how and who they worshipped.



JADEITE JAGUAR MASK
Olmec, 900–300 BCE



JADE MASK
Aztec, c.1420–1519



CARVED FROG
Aztec



JADEITE FIGURE
Aztec, 1500–1530



MOTHER AND BABY
Teotihuacan, c.200 CE



CARVED JAGUAR BONES
Maya, 400 CE



JADEITE CARVING
Maya, 600–900 CE



PITCHER
Inca, 1476–1550



STIRRUP POT
Moche, 200–500 CE



MARBLE VASE
Maya, 600–1000 CE



GOLD CUP
Sicán (Andean culture)



FIGURE OF A WOMAN
Inca, c.1476–1550



GOLD LLAMA
Inca